

Chapter 151 - Part 1

No one could help her answer this question.

Xu Qingzhu herself couldn't figure it out either. She only knew that she was extremely irritable, and her whole body was in pain.

Yet there were clearly no wounds.

The sun in this foreign land carried warmth, unlike the cold winter sun of Haizhou City.

But Xu Qingzhu still felt cold all over.

She sat on the bed with her arms crossed, her entire complexion pale, her forehead covered in cold sweat.

She opened her mouth numbly, but didn't know what to say, and finally closed it again.

Both the room and the phone fell into a deathly silence.

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu said coldly: "Go back to sleep. I need some quiet."

Without waiting for Liang Shi to react, she hung up the phone.

Xu Qingzhu turned her face to look outside. The hotel's glass was wiped spotlessly clean, and sunlight penetrated through, bright and dazzling.

Her phone didn't ring, but after a while, she received a message from Liang Shi.

【Babe, don't feel bad. When you're ready, tell me what happened. I'll be here all day.】

Xu Qingzhu stared at the screen for a long while, then closed her phone and tossed it aside.

She lay on the bed somewhat dejectedly.

She fell asleep again, and was once again jolted awake by the nightmare.

The same dream, the same suffocating feeling.

Xu Qingzhu refused to give in. After recovering slightly, she tried to fall asleep again.

From initially falling asleep quickly to later lying there with her brain playing images like a slideshow, it became very difficult to fall asleep.

For almost the entire afternoon, she was wrestling with her dreams.

Rather than wrestling with her dreams, it was more like wrestling with herself.

Everything in the dreams kept telling her: Liang Shi is going to kill you.

And when Liang Shi was killing her, someone would reach out to help her.

Xu Qingzhu fell into dreams again and again, and was frightened awake again and again.

Dreams had become the thing she feared most.

Once, after waking up, she had the impulse to call Liang Shi again and ask her why she wanted to kill her.

But before she could make the call, she came to her senses first.

This was too painful.

So painful that she didn't want to sleep. Her entire mood was low, and even her mental state was affected. That night, she inexplicably lost her temper at the secretary.

During this time, Liang Shi sent her several messages asking how she was doing.

She replied with text messages: 【Feeling better.】

And another: 【Busy.】

Cold and distant.

Xu Qingzhu didn't know how to suppress this emotion, so she drank a lot of alcohol before bed.

After drinking too much, she received a message from Liang Shi: 【Are you done with work? Is it convenient to video call?】

Xu Qingzhu replied with: 【Mm.】

At that moment, she was sitting in a chair in her room—more accurately, she was curled up in the chair with both legs pulled up, arms hugging her legs. It was a very insecure posture.

On Liang Shi's side, it was still evening. The sky was filled with rosy clouds, the orange-pink clouds like blush on a young girl's face, dreamlike and ethereal.

She was sitting on the bay window in the room, with Xu Qingzhu's pile of plushies behind her.

Her overall state wasn't good, somewhat dejected.

She looked at Xu Qingzhu. "Have you been drinking?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded, pressing her temples as she said: "I've been having nightmares all day."

"What nightmares?" Liang Shi asked. "Can you tell me?"

"I dreamed that you were going to kill me," Xu Qingzhu said. "My heart hurts so much..."

Xu Qingzhu had drunk too much, and her words came out sad and pained: "I feel like I'm being torn apart. One half says you're not that kind of person, while the other half keeps replaying the scenes of you killing me."

"Kill you?" Liang Shi pressed her lips together, her voice deep. "With what?"

Xu Qingzhu stared at her through the screen: "A knife."

Xu Qingzhu's eyes suddenly lit up. "A very sharp knife."

"Do you believe it?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu paused for a moment, then slowly shook her head.

But after just a moment, her eyes showed confusion and pain. "But it hurts so much."

"Where?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together and answered very slowly: "My heart, and here... and here..."

She pointed to behind her ear and her chest.

"I... I feel like I'm being influenced by something." Xu Qingzhu tried hard to distinguish between the two states. "I can't resist it. Once I try to resist, that thing clings to me desperately... I... I have no way out."

Her brows furrowed tightly.

Liang Shi fell silent after hearing this.

Chapter 151 - Part 2

Both sides were very quiet. After a long while, Liang Shi finally said: "I'll say it again—I will never hurt you."

Xu Qingzhu looked at her in astonishment and asked blankly: "How am I supposed to believe that?"

"If I had a knife in my hand," Liang Shi said, "the blade would surely be pointed at myself."

Her tone was resolute, her gaze firm as she looked at Xu Qingzhu.

As if she wanted to transmit strength to Xu Qingzhu through the camera.

Liang Shi called her name solemnly: "Xu Qingzhu, you know I won't lie to you."

"Then do you..." Xu Qingzhu looked at her. "Know something?"

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Your expression is so calm about this state I'm in. So, what do you know?"

Liang Shi didn't know what to say for a moment.

After a pause, Liang Shi said: "You don't need to know this."

"You said you wouldn't lie to me," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "....."

"I'm not the person you're supposed to be with." Liang Shi said this with great difficulty, closing her eyes briefly. "You're supposed to be with someone else. You'll have two lovely daughters together. That person is brilliantly talented and exceptionally capable. You two will love each other very much."

"Then... can a person love two people at the same time?" Xu Qingzhu asked her very seriously.

Liang Shi paused: "No, right?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "So... why would I love someone else?"

"Even with love," Xu Qingzhu said, "shouldn't it be first come, first served?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Xu Qingzhu's tone was serious and earnest, making one involuntarily follow her line of thinking. Liang Shi also sighed in agreement: "That's true."

"So I've already fallen in love with you." Xu Qingzhu couldn't figure it out. After drinking, her mind was working slowly, and she asked with unusual seriousness: "So why would there be someone else? Where do all these 'supposed to's come from?"

"But can't you not love me right now?" Liang Shi knew she wouldn't remember after she sobered up. Her habit of blacking out when drunk allowed Liang Shi to speak freely: "You'll feel like I'm going to hurt you, so you'll start doubting me, distancing yourself from me..."

"I won't." Xu Qingzhu stared at her and suddenly smiled. Her voice lost its earlier coldness and gained a touch of gentleness: "Teacher Liang."

Liang Shi was startled: "Huh?"

"Have you heard a saying?" Xu Qingzhu asked her.

Liang Shi: "What?"

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together and answered, almost word by word: "I will defy my instincts and continue to love you."

In Xu Qingzhu's world, there weren't that many "supposed to's."

What she wanted to do was simple—love Liang Shi.

Chapter 151 - Part 3

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Liang Shi didn't sleep well that night. She tried calling for that useless system, but got no response.

Last night, she had been on the phone with Xu Qingzhu for over three hours, until her phone ran out of battery.

She woke up very early in the morning. Lying in bed with her eyes open, her mind was clear, but she just didn't want to get up.

After dawdling for a long time, she finally sat up. Her mood was really bad.

She tried calling for the system again, but still got no response.

So useless.

When she got up and finished washing, a strange mechanical voice suddenly sounded in her mind: 【Hello, Host! What did you call Little Tong for? Have you finished collecting all the evidence? Little Tong will definitely submit the materials to the Interstellar Court, please rest assured!】

Liang Shi: "....."

How was this a golden finger system?¹

It was purely a debt collector.

It only communicated with her when issuing tasks and completing tasks. The rest of the time, it was just useless.

Liang Shi didn't have time to complain about it. There were more important things to do right now. "It's not about the evidence."

System: 【Then what is it?】

"If I want to forcibly change the world's consciousness—that is, the original plot—is there any way to do it without getting hurt?" Liang Shi said. "What I roughly understand now is that if I change the original plot line, I'll actually receive equal harm in return. That's your so-called balancing mechanism. Is there any way to change the original plot line without getting hurt?"

This long string of words confused the system.

But Liang Shi didn't know if it was confused or just unwilling to answer her. In any case, the system was silent for a long time before seriously saying: 【Host, before asking this question, you need to understand something first.】

Liang Shi: "What?"

System: 【The planar world has its own set of operating laws. As the managers of all planar worlds, we also cannot change the operating laws of a planar world. At the same time, when you—an unstable factor—were placed here, this became a Schrödinger's planar world.】 ²

Liang Shi: "....."

She didn't expect to get a science lesson here too.

But Liang Shi roughly understood.

"So you're saying that everything happening in this world right now is unknown. The operating laws of the planar world are maintaining its original order, and as an 'anomaly,' I'll be targeted by the planar world? In other words, my best choice is to comply with the planar world's original operating laws?"

The system was silent for a moment before saying: 【According to regulations, that's correct. But the laws won't target you specifically—they treat everyone equally.】

"Then why did you place me here? Or rather, why did you swap me with the original host? Does this swap comply with your operating rules?" Liang Shi's mind was working rapidly, wanting to extract some information from the system.

The system answered quite readily: 【It doesn't comply.】

Liang Shi: ".....?"

【But over tens of millions of years, countless people make wishes. If a god hears your wish, you become one of the lucky ones.】

【When someone chosen by a god doesn't cherish what they have and causes too much harm to others' destinies, the Administration will step in to balance things. However, the Administration won't interfere with the planar world's original operation.】

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi more or less understood now.

To summarize, the operating laws of the planar world couldn't be changed. In other words, there was no way to change the current predicament.

But that incident with Chen Liuying back then... hadn't she gotten through it?

Chen Liuying's ending in the original book wasn't great, but it wasn't bad either—she was a popular actress.

But now?

She was already in prison.

So what the system said was right—this was a Schrödinger's planar world.

What it would become, the choice was in her hands.

She was just worried about hurting Xu Qingzhu...

As for herself, it was fine. She had already been through storms and waves.

Liang Shi asked the system: "Then since Xu Qingzhu is someone you're supposed to protect, why is she still being interfered with by the planar world? And making her suffer so much, forcibly interfering with her will."

Xu Qingzhu's dreams should be what the original host did to her in the original plot line.

Since it hadn't happened in reality, she was made to dream about it frequently to interfere with her judgment.

Dreaming about it was one thing, but why make her experience that pain firsthand again and again?

Every time Liang Shi closed her eyes, all she could see was Xu Qingzhu's pained and confused face. She couldn't sleep well at all.

The system fell silent again.

After a moment, the system answered: 【Xu Qingzhu is not someone the Administration is meant to protect. Her fate line is tightly connected to yours and the original host's. Everything the original host did to her is to be compensated by you. The original host's body and soul have been reclaimed, while you remain intact in your original world.】

"Since the original host and I swapped, why should I be responsible for compensating her?"

As if she was determined to argue with the system, Liang Shi asked, getting to the bottom of things.

In reality, she still wanted to see if the system would reveal any flaws.

Liang Shi understood this as a maze—no matter how complicated it was, there must be a way out.

Like the incident with Chen Liuying. If the system hadn't made an error, she wouldn't have had to suffer so many injuries.

Moreover, she should have had other solutions that day; she just chose that particular one.

Each solution corresponded to a different outcome.

This was truly a Schrödinger's planar world.

If Liang Shi understood correctly.

She listened to the system's answers very carefully, wishing she could split each word in half to interpret it.

1. Golden finger (金手指): A Chinese web novel term referring to a special cheat-like ability, system, or advantage given to the protagonist that helps them succeed. ⇐
2. Schrödinger's planar world: A reference to the famous thought experiment "Schrödinger's cat" by physicist Erwin Schrödinger. The concept suggests that until observed or a choice is made, multiple outcomes exist simultaneously. Here, it means the world's outcome is undetermined until Liang Shi makes her choices. ⇐

Chapter 151 - Part 4

System: 【Because while she gained, she was also constantly giving and constantly being hurt. She bore a lot of harm in your place, so you're responsible for cleaning up the mess she left behind. That's easy to understand, right?】

Liang Shi: "But exchange is mutual. When I gained, I also lost, and so did she. I became her and cleaned up her mess. According to your balancing mechanism, shouldn't I be compensated for something?"

System: 【.....A chance at new life.】

The system was pressed by Liang Shi's questions: 【Your consciousness had already dissipated in the other world. You became a vegetable and couldn't wake up. Isn't your life precious enough? It was because of your good performance that the original host's soul and body were detained, allowing you to return to this world.】

While the original host could only be imprisoned in the interstellar prison.

The system continued: 【I roughly understand what you mean. There's no need to beat around the bush.】

It was a bit unsettling to hear this strange mechanical voice say such humanized words, but it seemed like compared to before, this system had become somewhat more intelligent.

Before Liang Shi could speak, the system said: 【You want to ask me whether, under the original world's operating laws, if you forcibly change the world line, you can avoid hurting Xu Qingzhu, right?】

Liang Shi: ".....You're quite smart."

System: 【The answer is unknown. The world's balancing laws only activate under extremely special circumstances—it's not constantly balancing. Moreover, the harm that comes from forcibly changing the operating laws is random, borne by people related to the relevant events. As a main figure in this event, Xu Qingzhu has a 33.34% probability of being harmed.】

Liang Shi: "....."

Good grief, now it was throwing probability at her.

But... why 33.34%?

System: 【You, Xu Qingzhu, Lu Jiayi.】

This time the system didn't speak in riddles and told her directly. It also told her: 【As compensation for the last world bug, Little Tong kindly reminds you: Lu Jiayi is already in Haizhou City.】

Liang Shi: "Whose side are you actually on?"

System: 【.....】

System, feeling aggrieved: 【Within what the rules allow, I'm on your side.】

Its attempt to imitate Liang Shi's Beijing accent¹ sounded nothing like it, making one feel irritated just listening.

Before it disappeared, it reminded Liang Shi: 【You've already crossed paths with her.】

Liang Shi: "....."

This conversation with the system wasn't entirely useless, but she still hadn't found a solution.

Moreover, Liang Shi couldn't think of where she would have met Lu Jiayi.

Even with so many things weighing on her mind, what needed to be done still couldn't be neglected.

She sent a message reminding Xu Qingzhu to drink honey water after waking up, and to rest more if she had a headache. Then, after washing up, she went to 79 Guanghua Street.

Today was the boot ceremony², and there would be a boot banquet in the evening. There were quite a few more people than when Liang Shi had come before. The crew wasn't as large as other productions—you could say it was quite small.

Adding in the extras, there were about forty to fifty people in total.

Liang Shi mingled in the crowd, still unable to muster any energy.

Fortunately, there weren't many scenes on the first day. She was just a bit out of it and needed three takes to pass.

After getting into the zone later, the progress picked up.

Everyone in this production was relatively inexperienced in acting, so Gu Yixue had to put in more effort.

Clearly, Gu Yixue was experienced in this area, so training them came naturally to her.

Among these people, Liang Shi was already considered outstanding.

Facing Sun Chengcheng's arrogance and mockery, Liang Shi wasn't in the mood to be roundabout and shot back directly: "You act so well, but didn't you also need three takes?"

Sun Chengcheng's face turned red with anger.

Being in different places and unable to meet, no amount of verbal comfort was useful.

Fortunately, nothing like that happened to Xu Qingzhu after that.

Until Saturday.

Liang Shi had been waiting early for Xu Qingzhu to return, but Xu Qingzhu said she still had to attend a banquet and could only come find Liang Shi after it ended.

As it happened, Liang Shi had evening scenes that day, probably filming until past midnight, so she said there was no rush.

But unexpectedly, in the evening, Sun Chengcheng said she had something to do and needed to ask Gu Yixue for time off.

Tonight was supposed to be Sun Chengcheng's major scenes.

Gu Yixue hesitated and asked what she needed to do.

Liang Shi happened to be beside Gu Yixue. She heard Sun Chengcheng hemming and hawing for a while before finally saying: "My father is taking me to attend a banquet."

Gu Yixue's brows furrowed slightly. She paused for a moment. "The Qin family's one?"

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1. Beijing accent / 兒化音 (érhuàiyīn): A distinctive feature of the Beijing dialect where an "r" sound is added to the end of certain words. The system's attempt to copy Liang Shi's natural speech pattern sounds awkward and unnatural. ↩
 2. Boot ceremony (開機儀式): A traditional ceremony in Chinese film and television production held on the first day of filming. It typically involves prayers, incense burning, and other rituals to wish for a smooth production. The "boot banquet" (開機宴) is the celebratory dinner that follows. ↩